



OFFICIAL

NMHS PROCEDURE

Medication: Safe Administration of Liquid Medications

Scope (Audience)	All NMHS Mental Health Services (MHS) Clinical Staff
Scope (Area)	All NMHS MHS Clinical Areas
Summary	To minimise the risks associated with the administration of liquid medication via the wrong route.
Risk Rating	Medium
Policy Standards	Clinical Governance (Std 1) Medication Safety (Std 4)
Policy Sponsor	Director of Medical Services MHSDHS
Policy Contact	Chief Pharmacist MHSDHS
Version	3.1
Review Date	23/03/2028

COMPLIANCE WITH THIS DOCUMENT IS MANDATORY

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1. Aim

To minimise the risks associated with the administration of liquid medication via the wrong route.

2. Background

There is an identified risk of serious “wrong route” medication errors resulting from accidental parenteral administration of solutions intended for oral, enteral or nebuliser delivery. Incidents involving oral, enteral and nebuliser solutions incorrectly administered parenterally have been reported nationally and internationally. This has prompted a review of techniques used for the administration of non-injectable medicines.

The [Australian Commission for Safety and Quality in Health Care](#) follows the acronym ‘APINCHS’ which classifies medicines with high potential for medication-related harm. The ‘S’ symbolises ‘Safer Systems’ which includes the safe administration of liquid medications.

Refer to the [WA High Risk Medication Management Policy MP 0131/20](#).

3. Risk

Oral, enteral and nebuliser liquids administered via the wrong route can be fatal or cause serious harm.

Non-compliance with this procedure will impact on the following risk categories:

Culture	☐	Organisational Development	☐
Emergency Management	☐	Policy & Legislative Compliance	☒
Fiscal Responsibility	☐	Quality of Patient Care	☒
Governance & Accountability	☒	Research & Innovation	☐
Information Communications Technology	☐	Staff Safety & Wellness	☐
Facility Management	☐	Workforce Planning	☐
Medical Equipment	☐	Other	☐

4. Principles

Western Australian public hospitals and health care facilities are required to follow these minimum requirements for oral, enteral or nebuliser solution administration:

- Non-Luer connectors/taper oral syringes (also known as dispensers) **MUST** be used to measure and administer non-injectable solutions, such as, oral, enteral or nebuliser liquids. These syringes **must not** be compatible with parenteral giving sets and entry portals.
- Order via hospital stores.

5. Administration of Oral or Enteral Solutions

- Solutions for oral or enteral administration **MUST** be administered using the specifically designed colour-coded syringes and devices.
- Oral syringes must have a distinguished colour plunger or barrel, different from parenteral syringes.

- Use devices to assist in the withdrawal of doses from liquid containers, such as transfer straws and stoppers to avoid the use of needles. Do not use needles to draw up oral, enteral or nebuliser solutions.
- Use bottle adapters (bungs) to assist drawing doses from liquid containers.
- Syringes **MUST** be clearly labelled with 'For Oral Use Only' or 'For Enteral Use Only.'
- All **scheduled** liquids **MUST** be measured using a colour-coded syringe and bung.
- Unscheduled liquids such as lactulose, sorbitol and antacid preparations may be measured using a metric graduated medicine cup.
- Doses should be prepared for immediate use only.
- Store colour-coded oral syringes separately from parenteral syringes and clearly identify storage areas.
- Oral syringes are single use only.

Refer to [WA Guideline on oral liquid Schedule 4 Restricted and Schedule 8 medicines](#)

6. Administration of Solutions for Inhalation

When using liquids required for inhalation, it is recommended that:

- Where possible, single use nebulisers be used, to avoid the need to draw solutions into a syringe.
- If single use nebulisers are not available, a non-Luer syringe **MUST** be used to draw up the dose prior to administration.
- Nebuliser solutions **MUST** be labelled 'For Inhalation Use Only.'

7. Roles and Responsibilities

Roles	Responsibilities
All NMHS MHS staff	Are responsible for: • Having knowledge of the procedure documents relevant to their roles and how to access these documents. • Complying with mandatory requirements outlined in these documents. • Assisting with procedure development/reviews wherever required. • Reporting to their immediate line manager any potential non-compliance or implementation issues.

8. Monitoring and Evaluation

Compliance with this procedure is mandatory.

Evaluation:

- Zero reports on Datix CIMS of medication incidents involving oral, enteral or nebuliser solutions.
- Zero medication discrepancy reports due to the use of incorrect equipment.

This procedure will be evaluated as required to determine its currency, relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, and sustainability. At a minimum, it will be reviewed every two years using a risk management approach in accordance with the [NMHS Policy Governance Framework](#).

9. References

- [National Safety & Quality Health Standards Ed 2 Nov 2017](#)
- [Australian Commission for Safety and Quality in Health Care](#)
- [WA Health Medicines Handling Policy](#)
- [WA High Risk Medication Management Policy MP 0131/20](#)
- [WA Guideline on oral liquid Schedule 4 Restricted and Schedule 8 medicines](#)
- [National Standard for User-applied Labelling of Injectable Medicines, Fluids and Lines](#)

10. Related Documents

Legislation	• Medicines and Poisons Act 2014 • Medicines and Poisons Regulations 2016
WA Health mandatory policies	• WA Health Medicines Handling Policy (MP 0139/20) • WA High Risk Medication Management Policy MP 0131/20

11. Document Control

Document Version Control			
Date	Version	Author	Notes
30/12/2015	V1.0	Patrick Marwick	
31/01/2019	V2.0	MHEG	Out of Session via email
04/02/2019	2.0	Chair, DTC/Chief Pharmacist, NMHS MH	Scheduled review: new template, change of policy title (previously "Safe Administration of Oral, Enteral or Nebuliser Solutions") and policy sponsor, updated hyperlinks, references and standards.
27/08/2020	2.1	Chief Pharmacist, NMHS MH	Links updated
11/08/2022	V3.0	NMHS MH Chief Pharmacist	Scheduled review; new template; updated hyperlinks; added information regarding High Risk – Safer Systems.
23/03/2026	V3.1	NMHS MH Chief Pharmacist	Scheduled review; new template; updated hyperlinks, changed to procedure

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Within the Department of Health WA, the term Aboriginal is used in preference to Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander, in recognition that Aboriginal people are the original inhabitants of Western Australia. No disrespect is intended to our Torres Strait Islander colleagues and community.

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